



**UNIVERSITY OF
PERPETUAL HELP
SYSTEM DALTA**



Loss of Spark: Understanding Emotional Detachment in Romantic Relationships

An Undergraduate Thesis Presented to
The Faculty of the College of Arts and Sciences
University of Perpetual Help System DALTA - Molino Campus
Molino III, Bacoar City

In Partial Fulfilment of the Requirements for the Degree of
Bachelor of Arts in Psychology

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April 2026



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“Loss of Spark: Understanding Emotional Detachment in Romantic Relationships”

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

The researchers would like to sincerely thank every individual who helped them finish their study, "Loss of Spark: Understanding Emotional Detachment in Romantic Relationships."

First and foremost, we would like to express our gratitude to our research adviser for all of his help, advice, and insightful recommendations during the study process. His knowledge and support were really helpful to us in raising the quality of this research.

We would especially want to thank all of the participants who voluntarily contributed their time, experiences, and stories. This study would not have been possible without their participation and openness.

We also thank our family and friends for their constant encouragement, understanding, and support during the course of this study.

Above all, we sincerely thank God for giving us the courage, wisdom, and determination to complete this study.

The Researchers



DISCLAIMER

This study is conducted for academic purposes only, and the findings are based solely on the responses of the selected participants; thus, they should not be generalized to all individuals or romantic relationships. The research involves discussions of emotional detachment, which may include sensitive personal experiences; however, it does not intend to diagnose, treat, or provide professional psychological advice. The accuracy of the results relies on the honesty and sincerity of the participants' responses. All information gathered is treated with strict confidentiality and will be used exclusively for academic purposes, with participants' identities remaining undisclosed. While efforts have been made to ensure objectivity, some degree of unintentional bias may still be present.



ABSTRACT

Romantic relationships play a significant role in psychological well-being, yet emotional connection within these relationships may change over time. One common experience reported by individuals is emotional detachment, often described as a “loss of spark,” which can affect relationship satisfaction and personal well-being. This study aims to explore and understand the lived experiences of young adults who have encountered emotional detachment in their romantic relationships. Using a qualitative approach, the study employed Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis (IPA) to capture participants’ meanings and interpretations of their experiences. Data were collected through semi-structured interviews with 6–10 purposely selected participants aged 18–35 from the CALABARZON region. Interviews were audio-recorded, transcribed verbatim, and analyzed using thematic analysis to identify recurring patterns and themes.

Keywords: Communication patterns; emotional detachment; interpretative phenomenological analysis; romantic relationships; young adults



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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND REVIEW OF LITERATURE

Background of the Study

Throughout the world, the significance of romantic relationships in the process of human development has been established due to scientific evidence indicating that relationships play a significant role in contributing to psychological wellbeing and happiness in one's life (Józefacka et al., 2023). The topic of relationship dynamics has been extensively examined by researchers who concluded that emotional connection, interaction, and interpersonal intimacy were essential components of the relationships that contribute to maintaining satisfaction and harmony in relationships (Rizzo et al., 2025). Nonetheless, it is common for a couple's emotional intimacy to evolve through time, and such changes often result in a loss of satisfaction and emotional distance in the relationships (Zhan et al., 2022).

The nature of romantic relationships in the Philippines can be defined by culture that places significant emphasis on the creation and establishment of meaningful relationships, close emotional ties, and social interactions. These are typical features of collectivist cultures that value harmonious interpersonal relations and emotional connectedness as core aspects of social life (Manalili & Malcampo, 2025). Filipino culture is focused on building harmonious relationships and emotional connectedness in interpersonal interactions, which can be important for the way in which people perceive their changing emotions within romantic unions (Patalita & San Jose, 2025). On the other hand, current social pressures such as poor



communication, stress, and changing expectations in young people can create barriers to emotional connection and even contribute to emotional distancing and changes in the level of satisfaction with romantic relationships (Rizzo et al., 2025). Since people's romantic relationships are known to affect their emotional and psychological state significantly, the study of changes in emotional connection in this regard has become crucial.

Romantic relationships have traditionally been considered synonymous with emotions, love, and understanding between partners (Reed, 2025). However, not all romantic relationships stay the same with regard to their emotional depth. Some people go through a period of gradually or suddenly feeling detached from each other emotionally, referred to as “loss of spark” . This situation is marked by a lack of emotional sensitivity, affection, excitement, and ultimately, a feeling of detachment from the lover (Steeped in Hope, 2026).

Emotional detachment in romantic relationships is a complicated process, which can be affected by various elements like problems with communication, unresolved conflict, stress, unfulfilled emotional needs, and dysfunctional interactions (Barry et al., 2008). The study of Prager et al., (2017) established that persistent conflict within a relationship and lack of adequate communication play important roles in increasing emotional distance between partners, while failure to meet one's emotional needs leads to undesirable emotional responses, which weaken the bond between individuals (Barry et al., 2008).

Moreover, according to Karney and Bradbury (1995), the factors that can affect the quality of relationships include stress, vulnerability, and adaptation. In situations when there



are unmet needs and unresolved stresses, the emotional intimacy of a couple may suffer, which contributes to dissatisfaction. Gottman (2026) highlights that such negative behaviors as criticism, defensiveness, and stonewalling negatively affect the overall level of satisfaction within the relationship.

Consequently, an individual might experience emotional detachment, which will lead to low relationship satisfaction and emotional discomfort (Callaci et al., 2020). The study of Barry et al. (2008) shows that prolonged emotional detachment may influence the perception of one's partner, leading to emotional emptiness and dissatisfaction. Sometimes, emotional detachment is the reason why couples decide to terminate their relationships (Civilotti et al., 2021).

Taking into account the above factors, numerous scholars have conducted research to understand the dynamics of romantic relationships, particularly concentrating on aspects such as communication styles, emotional intimacy, and relationship satisfaction. For instance, Lefebvre et al. (2026) revealed that emotional distancing serves as a coping strategy during conflicts; however, its excessive use can significantly affect the satisfaction and connection in the relationship. On the other hand, Rusbult et al. (2011) proposed an investment model that describes the dynamics of romantic relationships. It highlights that relationship commitment and satisfaction tend to diminish if rewards become insufficient and emotional costs escalate.



Moreover, Timmons, et al. (2023) indicated that emotional proximity and perceptions of responsiveness were strong predictors of relationship satisfaction, whereas emotional distance was associated with relationship dissatisfaction and less commitment. These findings reveal that emotional distancing does not occur in isolation; rather, it develops as a result of specific behaviors, emotional requirements, and relational dynamics which is aligned to the study of Pironne et al. (2023).

While prior studies have examined such things as relationship satisfaction, patterns of communication, and processes of commitment (Karney & Bradburry (1995); Barry et al., (2008; Timmons et al., 2023), not much attention has been devoted to examining what it means to feel detached or as if there is no longer any excitement in one's romantic relationship (Joel et al., 2020). Consequently, additional study is required in order to gain insight into these experiences.

The primary aim of this study is to explore the experience of individuals who have gone through emotional detachment, or "loss of spark" in their romantic relationship. More specifically, the study seeks to identify how these individuals conceptualize or explain emotional distancing, what contributes to the phenomenon, and its impact on relationship satisfaction and emotional bonding. This study will help uncover how individuals experience and explain emotional detachment within the context of their romantic relationship.

This study is related to the Sustainable Development Goal 3 that promotes Good Health and Well-being by ensuring healthy lives and promoting well-being of all people of



all ages. It is clear that emotional detachment within romantic relationships has a great impact on one's well-being and may cause emotional distress, dissatisfaction, and even decrease the levels of psychological health of an individual. Taking into account that SDG 3 focuses on the significance of mental health and well-being of an individual (Global Rewilding Initiative, 2026), the current topic becomes relevant to address the issues related to the quality of life.

The study is related to the University's Eight-Point Research Agenda, especially in areas such as Education, Social Sciences, Humanities, and Lifelong Learning since it focuses on studying the lived experiences of people in romantic relationships and examining emotional interactions between them. Furthermore, it is highly pertinent to topics such as Mental Health, Resilience, and Human Flourishing since emotional detachment is highly correlated with emotional disturbance, coping strategies, and overall mental well-being. Exploring the topic of 'loss of spark' within romantic relationships helps contribute to knowledge regarding emotional experience and resilience within personal relationships.

Review of Related Literature and Studies

This section presents an overview of emotional detachment in romantic relationships.

It includes the definition of emotional detachment, theoretical foundations, and factors contributing to emotional distancing such as attachment styles, communication



patterns, emotional regulation, personality traits, technological influences, stress, and intimacy-related variables. The section also highlights gaps in the literature that support the need for the present study.

Emotional Detachment in Romantic Relationships

Emotional detachment in romantic relationships has been widely explored in psychological and interpersonal research, particularly through frameworks such as attachment theory, emotional regulation, and communication patterns. Emotional detachment is commonly described as a reduction in emotional closeness, intimacy, and responsiveness between partners, often leading to dissatisfaction and relational instability (Lutf & Jayarathne, 2025). Understanding the mechanisms contributing to emotional detachment is essential because it affects relationship satisfaction, psychological well-being, and long-term relational stability.

Attachment Theory and Emotional Detachment

Attachment theory remains one of the most influential frameworks in understanding emotional detachment. Simpson (1990) demonstrated that individuals with insecure attachment styles, particularly those characterized by avoidance, tend to avoid emotional closeness and engage in distancing behaviors in romantic relationships. Supporting this claim, Delgado et al. (2023) found that insecure attachment styles characterized by anxiety and avoidance are significantly associated with maladaptive emotional regulation and reduced relational satisfaction. Similarly, Marszał and Jańczak (2020) reported that emotion



dysregulation is significantly linked to insecure attachment among adolescents, which contributes to emotional distancing in relationships. These findings highlight the role of attachment insecurity as a foundational factor in the development of emotional detachment.

Communication Patterns and Emotional Distancing

Communication patterns have also been consistently identified as central contributors to emotional detachment. Chiang and Bai (2022) emphasized that maladaptive communication behaviors such as criticism, defensiveness, contempt, and stonewalling predict emotional disengagement and relationship dissolution. Bretaña et al. (2022) further found that demand-withdraw communication patterns significantly predict emotional distancing over time, particularly when conflicts remain unresolved. Moreover, perceived partner responsiveness strengthens emotional closeness and protects against relational detachment (Rice et al., 2020). Ineffective communication contributes to both short-term disengagement and long-term relational instability (Körner & Schütz, 2021).

Loneliness and Emotional Detachment

Emotional detachment has also been linked to loneliness within romantic relationships. Xiao (2026) found that individuals may experience relational loneliness even while in committed partnerships, particularly when emotional needs remain unmet. Additionally, perceived emotional neglect has been identified as a stronger predictor of loneliness than physical absence, emphasizing the importance of emotional connection in maintaining relationship quality (De Heer et al., 2024). Emotional unconnectedness has also



been associated with increased symptoms of depression and relationship dissatisfaction (Osler, 2022).

Personality Traits and Individual Differences

Personality traits and individual differences have been explored as antecedents to emotional distancing. Bleckmann et al. (2024) found that individuals with high neuroticism and low agreeableness tend to experience greater relational conflict, which may contribute to emotional detachment. Similarly, Knox et al. (2023) reported that attachment avoidance and antagonistic personality traits are associated with increased emotional distancing in relationships. Personality incompatibility has also been identified as a factor contributing to relational instability and emotional disengagement (Ann, 2023).

Emotional Regulation and Emotional Closeness

Emotional regulation has been highlighted as another critical factor influencing emotional closeness. Individuals who use emotional suppression as a regulatory strategy report lower levels of intimacy and partner satisfaction (An et al., 2022). Furthermore, emotion regulation difficulties have been associated with increased relational conflict and emotional distancing (Valeria et al., 2022; Morgan et al., 2024). Conversely, adaptive emotion regulation strategies such as cognitive reappraisal are linked to greater relational

satisfaction and emotional closeness (Sternke et al., 2026). Emotional dysregulation has also been found to predict relational instability and detachment over time (Paulus et al.,



2021).

Self-Disclosure and Intimacy

Self-disclosure and intimacy are additional factors influencing emotional connection. Reduced self-disclosure is significantly associated with lower relationship satisfaction and emotional detachment (Candel & Turliuc, 2021). Emotional sharing strengthens intimacy, while lack of self-disclosure contributes to disengagement in relationships (Batthyany & Mokoena, 2025). Perceived partner responsiveness enhances emotional closeness and relationship stability (Rice et al., 2020). Emotional openness therefore plays a protective role against relational detachment (Kiełek-Rataj et al., 2020).

Technological Influences on Emotional Detachment

Technological influences have also emerged as modern contributors to emotional detachment. “Technoference,” or smartphone interruptions during interpersonal interactions, has been linked to reduced relationship satisfaction and emotional connection (Dixon et al., 2023). Social media use has also been associated with increased jealousy, comparison, and emotional distancing (Métellus et al., 2025). Problematic internet use has been linked to decreased intimacy and increased emotional disengagement (Gioia et al., 2021). Digital distractions negatively impact face-to-face emotional engagement over time (Massachusetts General Hospital, 2023).

Stress and Life Pressures



Stress and life pressures play a significant role in emotional detachment. External stressors reduce individuals' ability to respond emotionally, leading to decreased intimacy (Bayview Therapy, 2025). During the COVID-19 pandemic, external stress significantly affected emotional connection between partners, resulting in increased detachment (Bar-Shachar et al., 2022). Financial and occupational stress have also been shown to negatively affect relationship satisfaction and emotional closeness (Wei et al., 2024). Prolonged stress exposure may lead to cumulative emotional disengagement between partners (Schoen Clinic Group, 2025).

Sexual Intimacy and Emotional Connection

Sexual intimacy is closely connected with emotional intimacy in romantic relationships. Emotional closeness predicts sexual satisfaction, while lack of emotional intimacy has been linked to decreased sexual desire and activity (Ambrosini & Biolcati, 2024). Similarly, unmet emotional needs reduce both sexual frequency and satisfaction (Carcedo et al., 2020), further illustrating the bidirectional relationship between emotional and physical intimacy.

Synthesis

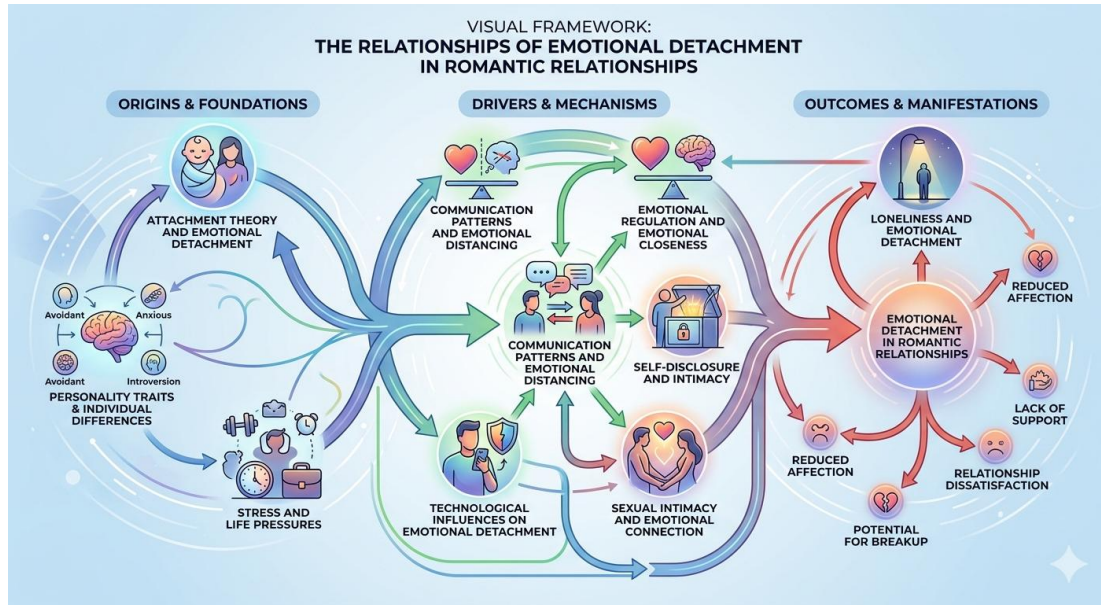


Figure 1. Visual Framework: The Relationship of Emotional Detachment in Romantic Relationships

Collectively, these studies suggest that emotional detachment results from the interaction of multiple factors, including communication difficulties, emotional regulation challenges, personality traits, technological influences, and external stressors. These factors do not operate independently but interact to progressively erode emotional intimacy and closeness within relationships. Despite the growing body of literature, much of the existing research remains quantitative, focusing primarily on measurable variables such as satisfaction levels and communication frequency. Consequently, there remains a need to explore the subjective experiences surrounding the progressive erosion of emotional intimacy. Addressing this gap, the present study aims to examine the lived experiences of individuals encountering emotional detachment in romantic relationships.



Statement of the Problem

This phenomenological study aims to explore and understand the lived experiences of individuals in romantic relationships who have encountered emotional detachment or a perceived “loss of spark.” It seeks to capture the essence and meaning of these experiences from the participants’ own perspectives.

Specifically, this study aims to answer the following questions:

1. What are the lived experiences of individuals who report a “loss of spark” in their romantic relationships?
 - 1.1 What situations do individuals identify as the beginning of emotional detachment?
 - 1.2 What emotions are commonly experienced during emotional detachment?
 - 1.3 What changes in affection do individuals notice toward their partner?
 - 1.4 What behaviors indicate emotional detachment in the relationship?
 - 1.5 What changes occur in communication during this phase?
 - 1.6 What role do conflicts or misunderstandings play in emotional detachment?
 - 1.7 What emotional needs are not met during this experience?
 - 1.8 What personal factors contribute to emotional detachment?
 - 1.9 What reactions do individuals observe from their partners?



- 1.10 What meaning do individuals give to the loss of spark in their relationship?
2. How do individuals describe, interpret, and make meaning of their experiences of emotional detachment over time?
- 2.1 How does emotional detachment gradually develop in relationships?
- 2.2 How does the frequency and quality of communication change over time?
- 2.3 How do patterns of conflict or avoidance contribute to detachment?
- 2.4 How do external factors (e.g., work, academics, social life) influence detachment?
- 2.5 How does emotional detachment affect trust between partners?
- 2.6 How does it impact physical intimacy and closeness?
- 2.7 How do individuals cope with or respond to emotional distance?
- 2.8 How do partners attempt to address or ignore the issue?
- 2.9 How does emotional detachment influence decisions to stay or leave the relationship?
- 2.10 How does the experience shape individuals' views on future relationships?



Theoretical Framework

Investment Model Theory

The Investment Model Theory was postulated by Rusbult in 1983, as a means of explaining the factors that contribute to commitment and satisfaction within a romantic relationship. Under the Investment Model Theory, there are three primary determinants of commitment in a relationship. These are satisfaction, quality of alternatives, and investment. In this regard, satisfaction involves the gains derived from the relationship minus its costs. On the other hand, the quality of alternatives is associated with the perceived attractiveness of alternative options such as other potential mates or even being single. Investment, on the other hand, entails the effort, emotional input, time, and personal sacrifice invested in a relationship. The more people believe they get more out of their relationship than they put in terms of effort, time, and sacrifice, the higher their likelihood of feeling committed. Conversely, reduced benefits and increased emotional costs can undermine satisfaction and commitment in a relationship (Rusbult, 2012).

The application of this theory to this research comes into play based on the fact that one reason for emotional detachment in romantic relationships is the realization that the amount of emotional gain experienced in the relationship is not enough as compared to the emotional loss. It is through such perceptions that individuals can have what is referred to as a "loss of spark," leading them to lose the drive needed for commitment in the relationship.



Therefore, using the model of investment can explain why certain individuals tend to feel detached emotionally from their partners based on the imbalance of gains and losses.

Vulnerability-Stress-Adaptation Model

According to Karney & Bradbury (1995), the Vulnerability-Stress-Adaptation (VSA) Model highlights the dynamics between personal vulnerability, stressors, and adaptation process and their role in determining relationship satisfaction or dissatisfaction. In the VSA model, the concept of vulnerability refers to the personal traits like an individual's personality, past behavior, or even emotions that may impact relationship behaviors. Stressors, in this case, refer to any external force that may create stress for couples, such as life problems or even environmental factors. The adaptation process, on the other hand, refers to any process that a couple undergoes in the relationship that helps them cope with stress and resolve conflict (Ross et al., 2022).

The Vulnerability-Stress-Adaptation Model is relevant for the present research because emotional detachment may emerge due to stress and inadequate adaptations, including ineffective communication and conflicts among partners. The presence of chronic stress along with the inability to cope with stress effectively results in the gradual decrease of emotional bonding between the partners. In turn, this may lead to unsatisfactory relationships and emotional detachment. Through the utilization of the VSA Model as the basis of the present study, the factors of stress, vulnerability, and behavioral patterns that result in the emergence of emotional detachment can be understood properly.



Emotion Regulation Theory

The theory of emotion regulation was developed by Gross in 1998 and describes how people regulate, determine the time of, and express their emotions. According to the theory, there are different strategies used by people to control the way they respond emotionally to particular situations. Such strategies can involve suppressing emotions, avoiding situations that can lead to an emotional reaction, reappraising or regulating emotions cognitively, and distancing from a situation. Emotion regulation is very important in interpersonal relationships as it helps people control their emotional responses when faced with some misunderstanding, conflict, or even stress while communicating with a partner.

However, emotional regulation can be associated with harmful consequences for the relationship itself. (Gillespie & Beech, 2016).

The application of this theory to the current study lies in the idea that emotional distancing acts as a coping mechanism during conflicts within the context of romantic relationships. People engage in emotional distancing as a means of coping with conflict situations and their emotions. On the other hand, where emotional distancing is practiced more often or for longer periods of time, emotional distancing reduces the intimacy between couples and the emotional connectedness between them. The Emotion Regulation Theory explains the coping process that people go through as far as emotions are concerned and the role of these coping mechanisms in developing emotional detachment.



Significance of the Study

This study may contribute to a deeper understanding of emotional detachment in romantic relationships, particularly in identifying its causes, manifestations, and effects on relationship stability and individual well-being.

It may benefit **individuals in romantic relationships** by increasing awareness of emotional disconnection, helping them recognize early signs of detachment and encouraging healthier communication and emotional responsiveness.

For **couples**, the findings of this study may provide insights that can support relationship maintenance and conflict resolution, potentially helping partners address emotional distance before it leads to relationship breakdown.

This study may also be valuable to mental **health professionals**, such as counselors and therapists, as it offers additional perspectives on emotional disengagement, which can inform therapeutic approaches and intervention strategies for couples experiencing relational strain.

For **educators and guidance counselors**, the results may help in developing programs or discussions that promote emotional awareness, relationship skills, and healthy interpersonal dynamics among students.



Lastly, this study may serve as a reference for **future researchers** who wish to further examine emotional processes in romantic relationships, including related topics such as attachment styles, communication patterns, and relationship satisfaction.

Scope and Delimitation

This study explores the lived experiences of individuals who have encountered emotional detachment, or a “loss of spark,” in their romantic relationships. Using a phenomenological approach, it focuses on how participants describe and interpret their experiences, including the factors contributing to emotional detachment, its development over time, its impact on intimacy, communication, and relationship satisfaction, and the coping mechanisms they employ.

The participants are individuals aged 18 to 35 years old who are currently or have previously been involved in a romantic relationship lasting at least six (6) months.

This study is limited to self-reported data and focuses solely on romantic relationships. It does not include other types of relationships or individuals outside the specified age range. Additionally, the findings are not intended to be generalized, as the study emphasizes in-depth understanding rather than broad application.

Definition of Terms

Attachment Style - Refers to a person's pattern of connection as well as behavior in romantic relationships, particularly with regard to dependency, closeness, and trust.



Communication Patterns - Refers to how couples interact with one another, communicate their thoughts, and settle arguments.

Coping Mechanisms - Refers to the approaches or strategies people apply to deal with interpersonal problems and emotional breakups.

Emotional Detachment - Refers to a situation where a person feels less intimate, close, or emotionally connected to their romantic relationship.

Emotional Regulation - Refers to a person's ability to control and react appropriately and effectively to emotional situations.

Loss of Spark - Refers to the gradual loss of interest, excitement, or emotional connection in a love relationship as experienced by the individual.

Relationship Satisfaction - Refers to how contented or fulfilled a person is in a romantic relationship.

Romantic Relationship - Refers to a secure, affectionate, and personal bond between two people that is marked by connection, love, and dedication.

Social Withdrawal - Refers to a person's potential to physically or emotionally distance oneself from their partner.

Young Adults - Refers to individuals aged 18 to 35 years old who are the target participants of this study.



CHAPTER 2

METHODOLOGY

Research Design

The research design that was adopted in this case is the Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis (IPA). The IPA is a qualitative research design based on phenomenology, developed by Jonathan A. Smith. The design involves examining how people construct and understand their own lived experiences. Unlike the descriptive approach, IPA enables the researcher to not only describe what is happening but also give an interpretation of why it happened (Smith et al., 2009).

The use of IPA allows researchers to perform qualitative analysis through identification of patterns, themes, and meanings from the stories of participants. In this way, it becomes possible to gain understanding of the interpretation of the experience that people have within the context of emotions and relations. Through the analysis of participants' stories, researchers are able to obtain insight into the experience that people had in order to make sense out of their emotional and interpersonal experience (Darley et al., 2025).

The reason behind the suitability of the IPA research design in this case is the fact that this design helps the researchers to analyze the way in which people construct meaning out of their experiences regarding the concept of being emotionally detached from their partners. This is due to the fact that the aim of this study is to analyze the experience of losing one's spark in a relationship and thus, IPA became quite an appropriate design for this purpose as it



deals with exploring the meaning of experiences of individuals (Willis & Harvey, 2025).

In contrast to grounded theory, where the emphasis lies on creating new theories (Tie et al., 2019), IPA is centered around discovering the meaning that participants find in their experiences. Similarly, while narrative inquiry concentrates on the order and structure of individual narratives (Lima, 2023), IPA takes storytelling further through the discovery of meaning in individual experiences. This was particularly relevant to this study since emotional disengagement in romantic relationships entails an intricate array of emotions, interpersonal interactions, and personal understanding of relational experiences. The use of IPA provided the researchers with an opportunity to explore more deeply how individuals understand the emotional shifts in their romantic relationships.

The research design applied in this study had an interpretivist epistemological stance, which posits that reality is socially constructed through individual experiences and meaning making. To acquire insights into the experiences of participants in romantic relationships, as well as their interpretations of the phenomenon under investigation, the researchers employed semi-structured interviews with each participant. In this case, information was obtained regarding the participants' perceptions of emotional detachment, the causes of loss of spark in romantic relationships, and the emotions and consequences associated with the experience. In this study, the data were subjected to IPA analysis through careful reading of transcripts, coding, and interpretation of themes and participants' narratives (Pervin & Mokhtar, 2022).



Participants Characteristics

Approximately 6–10 participants will be purposively selected to ensure diverse perspectives across age, gender, relationship status, and socioeconomic background, consistent with Ahmed (2024). This sample size is suitable for qualitative research, allowing for in-depth exploration of emotional detachment while representing the experiences of young adults in the region.

Eligibility Criteria:

- Individuals aged 18 to 35 years old
- Currently or previously involved in a romantic relationship lasting at least six (6) months
- Residing in the CALABARZON region
- Willing to participate in interviews and share personal experiences

Exclusion Criteria:

- Individuals not residing in the CALABARZON region
- Individuals unwilling or uncomfortable discussing their romantic experiences
- Individuals currently experiencing severe mental health conditions that may impair their ability to provide informed consent



Major Demographic Characteristics

Age: 18–35 years old

Location: Residents of the CALABARZON region

Relationship Status: Currently or previously in a romantic relationship

Relationship Duration: At least six months

Gender: Cisgender

Sampling Procedures

Procedure for Selecting Participants/Respondents

Participants will be selected using purposive sampling, a non-probability sampling technique in which decisions concerning the individuals to be included in the sample are taken by the researcher (Rai et al., 2015), based upon the eligibility criteria. This approach allows the researcher to intentionally choose individuals who have relevant experiences related to emotional detachment in romantic relationships.

The selection process will begin with the dissemination of a recruitment message through online platforms such as social media (e.g., Facebook, Messenger) and academic networks within the CALABARZON region. The message will include a brief description of the study, its purpose, and the eligibility criteria.



Interested individuals will be asked to respond through a screening form to determine whether they meet the inclusion criteria. The researcher will review the responses and select approximately 6–10 participants who best fit the study requirements while ensuring variation in age, gender, relationship status, and socioeconomic background.

Selected participants will then be contacted individually to confirm their willingness to participate. They will be provided with an informed consent form detailing the purpose of the study, confidentiality measures, and their rights as participants, including the option to withdraw at any time.

Once consent is obtained, interview schedules will be arranged at a time convenient for the participants. The researcher will ensure that all participants feel comfortable and safe throughout the process, especially when discussing personal experiences related to romantic relationships.

Research Instrument

This study utilized a semi-structured interview guide as the primary research instrument to explore emotional detachment in romantic relationships. A semi-structured interview is a qualitative data collection technique where questions are guided by established topics but allow for open-ended responses (Tegan, 2023).

The researchers provided flexibility for follow-up questions while using the same interview guide for each participant in order to ensure reliability. In order to maintain



accuracy, interviews were verbatim transcribed after being audio recorded with consent. To make sure that the participants' answers were accurately conveyed, the researchers carefully went over the transcripts.

Validation

To ensure content validity, the research instruments will be reviewed by at least two experts in the field of psychology who will evaluate the clarity, relevance, and appropriateness of the items. A pilot test will also be conducted with a small group of respondents to identify any uncertain or unclear questions and to improve the overall structure of the instrument.

Reliability

To ensure reliability, the researchers followed a consistent interview procedure for all participants. The same set of guide questions was used, while still allowing flexibility for follow-up questions when necessary.

Data Gathering Procedure

Before data collection, the researchers secured a formal approval from the College of Arts and Sciences and obtained ethical clearance. A semi-structured interview guide focusing on experiences, perceived causes, and outcomes of emotional detachment in romantic relationships among young adults aged 18–35 in CALABARZON was prepared by the



researchers. The guide was reviewed by experts in psychology for content validity and appropriateness for the target participants. A pilot interview with one to two eligible individuals was conducted to check clarity, sensitivity of questions, and estimated duration; minor revisions were made based on feedback.

Participants were recruited through purposive sampling using online platforms such as Facebook, Messenger, and academic networks. The study and its criteria, we invited interested individuals to complete a screening form. From this pool, we selected 6–10 participants, intentionally choosing a group that reflected a diverse range of ages, genders, relationship statuses, and socioeconomic backgrounds.

Eligible participants were contacted individually through their preferred communication channel. They received an electronic informed consent form explaining the study's objectives, voluntary nature of participation, confidentiality measures, and their right to withdraw at any time. Once consent was obtained, interview schedules were arranged at dates and times convenient for each participant. Depending on the participant's preference and safety considerations, interviews were conducted either face-to-face in a private setting or via secure online platforms\

Each interview began with rapport-building and a reminder of confidentiality. Interviews lasted 45–60 minutes and focused on experiences of emotional detachment, its triggers, coping strategies, and impacts. With consent, interviews were audio-recorded, and



field notes were taken to capture non-verbal cues and context. Participants' comfort and safety were prioritized throughout.

After each interview, participants were debriefed and referred to support services if needed. Recordings were transcribed verbatim, anonymized using codes, and stored securely. All data were kept confidential, retained for a limited period, and then securely deleted.

Data Analysis Procedure

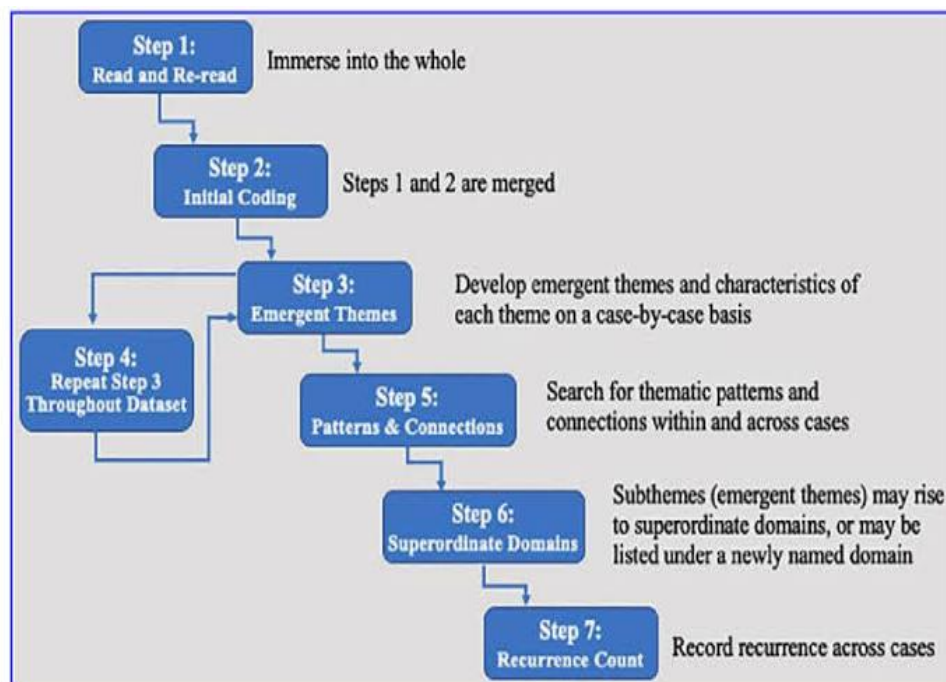


Figure 2. Steps to Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis (IPA) by Smith et al.



This study will use Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis (IPA) to understand how participants experience and make sense of emotional detachment in romantic relationships. IPA focuses on personal experiences and how people give meaning to those experiences. It also recognizes that the researcher plays an active role in interpreting the data (Smith et al., 2009; Smith & Osborn, 2015).

The data analysis will start after the data gathering process. The study will use semi-structured interviews, which will be audio-recorded with the participants' consent. These recordings will be transcribed word-for-word to make sure that the data is accurate. Important non-verbal cues, such as pauses and changes in tone, will also be noted when needed. Field notes taken during the interview will be used to support the transcript and give more contexts to the participants' responses (Pietkiewicz & Smith, 2014).

After transcription, the researcher will read each transcript several times to become familiar with the data. This step helps the researcher understand the participant's experience more clearly. Next, initial noting will be done. This includes descriptive comments (what the participant said), linguistic comments (how they said it), and conceptual comments (possible meanings of their statements) (Smith et al., 2009).

After making notes, the researcher will identify emergent themes. These are short phrases that capture the main ideas from the participant's responses. The researchers will then look for connections between these themes and group them into larger themes, also



called superordinate themes. This process may involve grouping similar ideas together or identifying differences between them (Larkin et al., 2006).

Each participant's data will be analyzed one at a time. This is important in IPA because it focuses on each person's unique experience. The researcher will not compare participants right away. After all individual analyses are complete; the researcher will look for patterns across all participants. This step helps identify common experiences as well as differences among them.

Finally, the results will be written in a narrative form. The themes will be explained and supported with direct quotes from the participants. This ensures that the findings are based on the actual experiences of the participants while also including the researcher's interpretation (Smith & Osborn, 2015).

The data analysis is closely connected to the data gathering process. Since the study uses purposive sampling and semi-structured interviews, the participants are chosen based on their relevant experiences. This allows the researcher to collect detailed and meaningful data, which is important for IPA. The process of collecting, transcribing, and analyzing data is done step by step to make sure that the findings are clear and reliable (Smith et al., 2009).



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APPENDICES

Appendix A. Interview Guide

What

1. Can you describe the situation when you first noticed emotional detachment in your relationship?
2. What emotions did you commonly experience during that time?
3. What changes did you notice in your affection toward your partner?
4. What behaviors made you realize that emotional detachment was happening?
5. How did your communication with your partner change during this phase?
6. In what ways did conflicts or misunderstandings contribute to emotional detachment?
7. What emotional needs do you feel were not met during this experience?
8. What personal factors (e.g., stress, past experiences, personality) contributed to your emotional detachment?
9. What reactions or changes did you observe from your partner?
10. What does the “loss of spark” mean to you in your relationship?

How

11. How would you describe the gradual development of emotional detachment in your relationship?
12. How did the frequency and quality of your communication change over time?



13. How did patterns of conflict or avoidance contribute to emotional detachment?
14. How did external factors (e.g., work, academics, social life) influence your relationship?
15. How did emotional detachment affect trust between you and your partner?
16. How did it impact your physical intimacy and emotional closeness?
17. How did you cope with or respond to the emotional distance?
18. How did you or your partner attempt to address or ignore the issue?
19. How did emotional detachment influence your decision to stay or leave the relationship?
20. How did this experience shape your views on future relationships?



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